There was, for instance, the case of Bernie Pitt.

As I had suspected might be the case at the very start, Bernie Pitt and Bill Boyd did not, in the long run, get along.

For months, it had been clear to me that Bernie disliked Bill, disapproved of his easygoing ways and of his occasional drinking, and utterly discounted his intelligence. As for Bill, his reaction to Bernie seemed to me to be one of increasing anger. Bernie's sardonic humor apparently rubbed him raw.

I kept gloomily apart from this, doing my best to remain detached and noncommittal when either criticized the other to me. I was unhappily aware that I might have warned Bill or Bernie, or both, at the start and that I had refrained from doing so out of the fear that I might have been wrong. But suppose I had warned each of them? Would either have believed me? And if they had, and had the association not been made, how could I have known for certain that things would have turned out as I had predicted?

By December, Bernie reported to me that Boyd had delivered an ultimatum to him to the effect that he had "two months to change his ways."

I was stirred by curiosity to ask, "What ways?"

Bernie shook his head. He didn't know.